

KARA JONES

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EDUCATION

Ph.D. Economics, University of South Carolina, expected May 2027

B.S.B.A. International Business and Economics, University of South Carolina Honors College, 2018

FIELDS OF SPECIALIZATION

Primary: Public Finance

Secondary: Regional Development, Urban Economics, Applied Microeconomics

DISSERTATION

Place, Policy, and Poverty: Essays on the Limits and Possibilities of Local Economic Intervention

Committee: Prof. Jason DeBacker (chair), Prof. Doug Woodward, Prof. Danna Thomas, Dr. Veronika Penciakova

JOB MARKET PAPER

“Poverty Reduction or Relocation? Long-Run Neighborhood Change Following Place-Based Policy”

I explore how place-based policies reshape neighborhoods over time by focusing on gentrification and population movement following Empowerment Zone (EZ) designation. Using restricted Census data, I track changes in housing costs, income composition, and migration flows at the tract level. I conceptualize gentrification as a process of neighborhood upgrading driven by rising costs and demographic turnover. A difference-in-differences approach compares treated areas to similar untreated neighborhoods to estimate how these dynamics evolve after designation. I find that zone designation raises incumbent income and employment in the short run, but the gains fade and vary by designation round. Housing costs and residential stability respond slightly, so overall previous residents are not displaced. Instead, the population becomes younger, less educated, and less white over time, which lowers average neighborhood income and education even though income and housing costs do not decline for previous residents.

PEER REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

“[Reindustrialization Meets Rural Reality: The Limits of FDI Led Development.](#)”

Published at *Contemporary Economic Policy*. Jul 2026.

WORKING PAPERS

“[Exempt, Evade, Enforce: Unpacking Property Tax Dynamics in the Short-Term Rental Market.](#)”

Under Review.

“Efficacy of Local Flavored E-cigarette Bans.” with Danna Thomas and Roxana Gonzalez-Cortes.

“Short Run Impacts of Place-based Economic Incentives.” with Jason DeBacker.

OTHER PUBLICATIONS

“[Game Theory and Why Economists Are Talking About ‘Geeconomics’ Again.](#)”

Published at *Common Good*. June 2026.

“[Closing the Airbnb Tax Loophole.](#)” Policy Brief through [SC EPiC](#) (Economics Policy Center)

Darla Moore School of Business, University of South Carolina. September 2026.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor, Honors College Senior Thesis Proseminar (undergraduate), University of South Carolina, Fall 2026

Instructor, Introduction to Economics (undergraduate), University of South Carolina, Spring 2026

Teaching Assistant, University of South Carolina, Fall 2021 – Spring 2026
Undergraduate level: Public Finance, Game Theory in Economics, Political Economy, Industrial Organization, Intermediate Microeconomics, Introduction to Economics, Introduction to Macroeconomics, Introduction to Microeconomics
Graduate level: Applied Microeconomics
Fulbright English Teaching Assistant, Escola Andoranna, 2018-2019

RESEARCH AND RELEVANT WORK EXPERIENCE

AEA 2025 Research Fellow, Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta, Summer 2025
Global Business Development Intern, South Carolina Department of Commerce, Summer & Fall 2023
Senior Consultant – Change Management and Learning, IBM Consulting, 2019 - 2022

GRANTS AND AWARDS

Darla Moore School of Business Doctoral Fellows Award, 2024 & 2026 - \$12,000 fellowship
University of South Carolina Graduate School Travel Grant, 2022 & 2026 - \$1,300 grant
Research Fellowship at Atlanta Federal Reserve Bank, Summer 2025
Southeastern Annual Economic Conference Graduate Student Award, 2024
Special Sworn Status, U.S. Census Bureau, 2023 - Present
Smith Richardson Foundation, 2023 – 2027, Co-PI, \$276,834 grant
U.S. Fulbright Grantee: Andorra, 2018 – English Teaching Assistantship
Dean's Award for Undergraduate Achievement, 2018

CONFERENCE AND SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

2027: American Economic Association (AEA) Conference (scheduled)
2026: Southern Regional Science Association Meeting (also a discussant), American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association International Conference, Clemson University Public Economics Workshop, Federal Statistical Research Data Center Annual Research Conference (scheduled), South Carolina State University (scheduled), Winthrop University (scheduled), Center for Economic Studies (scheduled), Southeastern Annual Economics Conference (scheduled)
2025: Evaluation of the Economic Impact from Short-Term Vacation Rentals Workshop, Atlanta Federal Reserve Bank, University of South Carolina Economics Department
2024: Southeastern Annual Economics Conference (also a discussant)
2022: Southeastern Annual Economics Conference

LANGUAGES

English (native), French (proficient), Spanish (intermediate), Mandarin Chinese (basic)

COMPUTATION SKILLS

Python, Stata, Latex, Git, SAS, Unix command line, zTree, WordPress

CERTIFICATIONS & MEMBERSHIPS

Ethical Human Research for Social and Behavioral Researchers (CITI Program), 2024 –2027
IBM Service Corps Alum, IBM, 2021
PhD Project, Member of Finance and Economics Doctoral Student Association
Association for Christian Economists, Member

ACADEMIC SERVICE

2026: Panelist for Fulbright Exploration Event, Fulbright Evaluation Committee Member – ETA to Senegal
2025: Fulbright Evaluation Committee Member – ETA to Belgium and Spain
2024: Fulbright Evaluation Committee Member – ETA to Andorra and Moldova, Volunteer SC High School Econ Day
2023 & 2022: Volunteer SC High School Econ Day